PRESIDENCY DESK · BRIEF 4 OF 4

Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence

Ireland hosts the European headquarters of most major American technology companies. This makes it a critical node in the EU's cyber threat surface — and uniquely positioned to lead on EU cyber resilience. The EU's hybrid threat response toolbox is under active development. Ireland will chair its next iteration.

Security Ireland

June 2026

KEY FINDINGS

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Ireland's concentration of tech-sector headquarters creates a shared EU threat surface: a successful cyber attack on Irish-hosted systems affects data integrity and service continuity across the entire Union. The 2021 HSE ransomware attack cost hundreds of millions and demonstrated the vulnerability. Four EU frameworks are being shaped during Ireland's Presidency: the EU Hybrid Toolbox (March 2026 Council conclusions to implement), the Cyber Diplomacy Toolbox, the Cybersecurity Crisis Blueprint, and NIS2 implementation. Ireland's tech-sector concentration means EU cyber resilience runs through Dublin. The Presidency is the window to convert that position into a permanent institutional role — or to leave it as a vulnerability others must cover.

The strategic objective

Ireland's strategic objective for the Presidency is to establish itself as a permanent, credible contributor to European security in the domains where its geography is irreplaceable — maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure protection, and cyber resilience — so that when the Presidency ends in December 2026, Ireland has locked in a role that outlasts the political window.

Cyber resilience is the domain where Ireland's contribution is most immediately credible. Ireland's technology sector — the European headquarters of Apple, Google, Meta, Microsoft, Amazon, and most other major American tech firms — makes Ireland a critical node in EU digital infrastructure. This is not a geographic asset like maritime surveillance. It is an institutional and economic asset. But it serves the same thesis: Ireland contributes to European security in a domain where its position is irreplaceable.

WHY HYBRID THREATS AND CYBER DEFENCE MATTER FOR THIS OBJECTIVE

Hybrid threats — coordinated campaigns combining cyber attacks, disinformation, infrastructure sabotage, and political interference — are the security challenge where Ireland's vulnerability is most acute and its potential contribution most distinctive. Ireland's NCSC remains under-resourced with a fragmented intelligence architecture unique in Europe. But Ireland's tech sector gives it unmatched expertise in cyber operations, data protection, and AI. The Presidency is the mechanism to convert this sectoral strength into a recognised EU defence contribution.

Ireland's hybrid threat surface

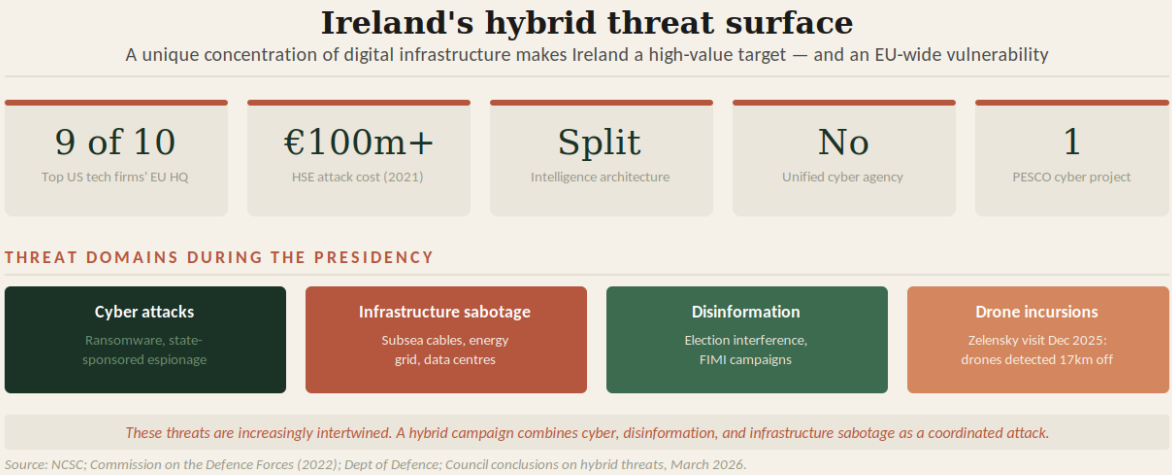

Figure 1: Ireland's hybrid threat surface. Nine of ten top US tech firms have their EU headquarters in Ireland. The NCSC remains under-resourced with a split intelligence architecture. The 2021 HSE attack demonstrated the vulnerability. Four threat domains — cyber attacks, infrastructure sabotage, disinformation, and drone incursions — converge during the Presidency.

Ireland hosts the European headquarters of most major American technology companies. This concentration of digital infrastructure creates a shared threat surface: a successful cyber attack on Irish-hosted systems affects data integrity and service continuity across the EU and beyond. The 2021 HSE ransomware attack cost hundreds of millions and demonstrated the vulnerability.

Ireland's NCSC remains under-resourced. Its intelligence architecture is split between military intelligence (IMIS) and police intelligence (Garda CSB) with no unified agency — a structure unique in Europe. During President Zelensky's visit in December 2025, unidentified drones were detected seventeen kilometres off the coast. Portugal's GNR provided drone defence near Leinster House. Six months before the Presidency, Ireland could not guarantee it could secure its own capital without foreign military assistance.

The EU frameworks being shaped

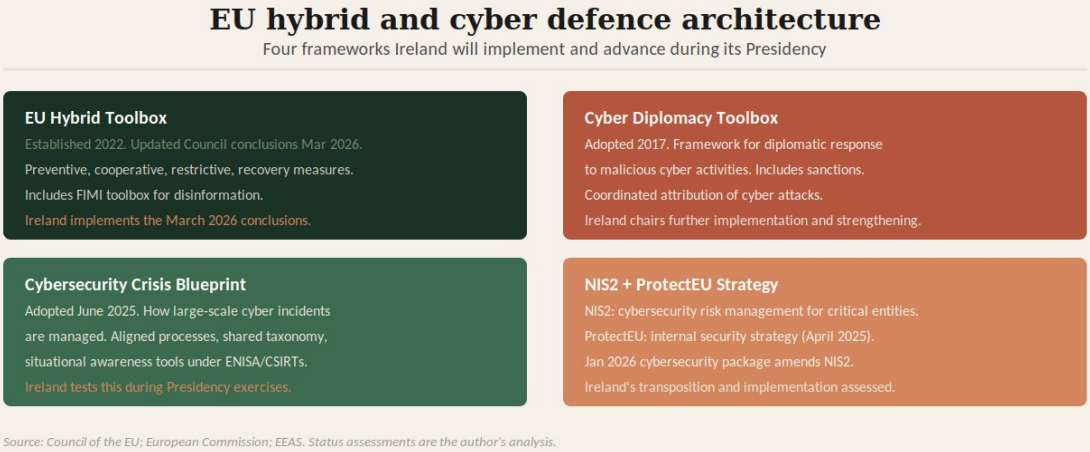

Figure 2: EU hybrid and cyber defence architecture. Four frameworks Ireland will implement and advance: the EU Hybrid Toolbox (March 2026 Council conclusions), the Cyber Diplomacy Toolbox, the Cybersecurity Crisis Blueprint (June 2025), and NIS2/ProtectEU implementation.

On 16 March 2026, the Council approved conclusions on advancing the EU's capacity to counter hybrid threats — condemning sabotage against critical infrastructure, malicious cyber operations, foreign information manipulation, election meddling, and the instrumentalisation of migration. Ireland will chair the implementation of these conclusions from July.

The EU Hybrid Toolbox provides a framework for coordinated response to hybrid campaigns. The Cyber Diplomacy Toolbox enables diplomatic response to malicious cyber activities, including sanctions and coordinated attribution. The Cybersecurity Crisis Blueprint, adopted June 2025, establishes how large-scale cyber incidents are managed across the EU. The January 2026 cybersecurity package amends NIS2 to simplify compliance and strengthen supply-chain security.

What's being decided during Ireland's term

Figure 3: Key decisions during Ireland's Presidency. Four hybrid/cyber decisions Ireland chairs: implementing the March 2026 hybrid conclusions, testing the Crisis Blueprint, ensuring cyber qualifies as EDIP participation, and embedding cyber in the MFF.

1. Hybrid toolbox implementation

The March 2026 Council conclusions call for further implementation, strengthening, and development of the EU Hybrid Toolbox and Cyber Diplomacy Toolbox. Ireland chairs the Council that implements these conclusions. The specific actions — how hybrid rapid response teams are deployed, how FIMI monitoring is extended, how attribution mechanisms are strengthened — are shaped during Ireland's term.

2. Cybersecurity crisis exercise

The 2025 Cybersecurity Crisis Blueprint should be tested during Ireland's Presidency through a live exercise. Ireland should host the exercise, demonstrating NCSC

integration with EU crisis mechanisms and testing the Irish node of the CSIRTs network. This makes Ireland a tested participant in EU cyber crisis response, not just a signatory.

3. Cyber defence in EDIP implementing rules

The government is already moving on the domestic side: the Minister for Enterprise is examining restrictions on Enterprise Ireland's dual-use engagement, and the Minister for Justice is introducing interim security clearances for Irish firms seeking EU defence contracts. But these domestic reforms only matter if the EU rules recognise what Ireland offers. The EDIP implementing rules define what counts as 'participation.' If participation means manufacturing, Ireland is excluded regardless. If it includes cyber, AI, and technology contribution, Ireland's tech sector can participate. Removing domestic barriers and shaping EU rules are two sides of the same door — the briefs connect.

4. Cyber resilience in the MFF

The next seven-year EU budget should include cyber resilience as a named priority domain. Ireland should draft the framework text. If the MFF defence chapter is written generically, cyber funding goes to states with military cyber commands. If cyber resilience is named, Ireland's NCSC and tech sector have a permanent funding pathway.

Figure 4: Ireland as EU cyber node. The tech-sector concentration is both Ireland's greatest asset (world-class expertise, GDPR hub, AI research) and its greatest vulnerability (under-resourced NCSC, fragmented intelligence, HSE-scale attack risk).

What Ireland should do

Four actions, each justified by how it advances the strategic objective of locking in Ireland's permanent cyber security role.

1. Lead implementation of the March 2026 hybrid conclusions

Ireland should use its Presidency to drive concrete implementation of the Council's hybrid threat conclusions. Priority areas: deploying hybrid rapid response teams, extending FIMI monitoring to all CSDP missions, strengthening coordinated attribution mechanisms, and advancing cooperation with NATO's hybrid centre of excellence. Ireland's tech sector gives it unique credibility in the cyber and disinformation domains.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland as the state that implemented the EU's most consequential hybrid threat framework update. The March 2026 conclusions are the reference text; Ireland's implementation shapes how they are operationalised.*

2. Host a Presidency cybersecurity crisis exercise

Ireland should host a live exercise under the new Cybersecurity Crisis Blueprint, testing NCSC integration with EU mechanisms and demonstrating Ireland's capacity to coordinate EU-wide cyber incident response. The exercise should simulate a hybrid campaign targeting Irish-hosted digital infrastructure — making the point that an attack on Irish systems is an attack on EU data integrity.

THIS LOCKS IN: *Ireland's NCSC as a tested, integrated node in EU cyber crisis response. An exercise creates institutional relationships and operational muscle memory that persist beyond the Presidency.*

3. Ensure EDIP recognises cyber and AI as eligible participation

Ireland should use its Presidency authority to ensure that the EDIP implementing rules include cyber, AI, and dual-use technology as eligible forms of participation. The domestic reforms underway — amending Enterprise Ireland restrictions, establishing security clearance processes — only deliver value if the EU rules on the other side recognise technology contribution. This is the Presidency-side complement to the domestic agenda.

THIS LOCKS IN: *A permanent pathway for Ireland's tech sector to participate in EU defence programmes. Ireland's economic strength becomes a recognised defence contribution.*

4. Embed cyber resilience in the MFF framework text

The defence and security chapter of the next MFF should name cyber resilience as a priority domain. Ireland should draft this text during its Presidency. If the MFF is written generically, funding flows to kinetic capabilities. If cyber is named, Ireland's NCSC and tech ecosystem have a permanent funding line.

THIS LOCKS IN: *Cyber resilience as a permanent category in the EU budget. Ireland's tech-sector position ensures it is always a relevant contributor to this domain.*

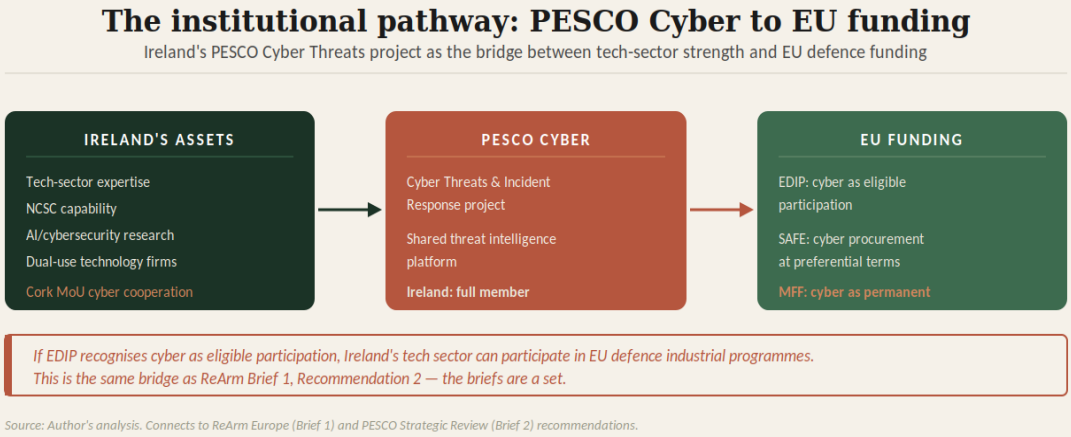

Figure 5: The institutional pathway from Ireland's tech-sector assets through PESCO Cyber to EU funding. If EDIP recognises cyber as eligible participation, Ireland's tech sector becomes part of the European defence industrial base. The briefs are a set.

What happens if Ireland doesn't act

The March 2026 hybrid conclusions are implemented by others. Ireland's tech-sector concentration remains a vulnerability the EU must work around, not an asset it can leverage. EDIP participation requires manufacturing — Ireland's cyber and AI expertise is excluded. The NCSC remains isolated from EU crisis mechanisms. The next HSE-scale attack finds Ireland no better prepared than in 2021.

Source: Author's analysis.

Figure 6: What Ireland locks in through active chairing — and what it loses through passive chairing. The difference is whether Ireland's tech-sector concentration becomes a permanent EU cyber security asset or remains an EU-wide vulnerability.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Ireland's technology sector is the asset that makes cyber resilience a domain of Irish leadership. But the asset requires institutional backing: an NCSC integrated into EU crisis mechanisms, a PESCO cyber project connected to EU funding, and EDIP rules that recognise technology contribution. The Presidency is the window. After December 2026, the frameworks are set.

Recommendations

#	Action	What it locks in	For whom	By when
1	Lead implementation of March 2026 Council hybrid threat conclusions: deploy rapid response teams, extend FIMI monitoring, strengthen attribution	Ireland as the state that operationalised the EU's hybrid threat framework	DFA Presidency team / EEAS / Hybrid CoE	Ongoing Jul–Dec 2026
2	Host Presidency cybersecurity crisis exercise testing NCSC integration with EU Blueprint mechanisms	NCSC as tested, integrated node in EU cyber crisis response	Dept of Defence / NCSC / ENISA	October 2026
3	Ensure EDIP implementing rules recognise cyber, AI, and dual-use technology as eligible participation	Permanent pathway for Irish tech sector in EU defence programmes	DFA / ITRE working group	October 2026
4	Draft MFF framework text naming cyber resilience as priority defence domain	Cyber resilience as permanent EU budget category	General Affairs Council / European Council prep	December 2026

A NOTE ON METHOD

This brief assesses EU hybrid threats and cyber defence frameworks through the lens of Ireland's strategic objective: locking in a permanent security role in its geographic and economic domains. It does not assess the technical adequacy of the NCSC or the operational merits of specific cyber capabilities. This brief asks: given that the EU's hybrid threat and cyber defence architecture is being shaped, what should Ireland do to ensure its tech-sector position is recognised as a permanent contribution?

Series context

Fourth and final in the Presidency Desk series — four briefs on the EU instruments Ireland must steer during its Council Presidency. Companion briefs: ReArm Europe; PESCO Strategic Review; Maritime Surveillance Cooperation.

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